

Linen

Made from the flax plant, linen is a cool, breathable fabric that is perfect for quilting. It is available in many different weights and can sometimes be found blended with cotton (cotton-blend). It can be expensive and difficult to work with. Always pre-wash and zigzag stitch the raw edges to minimize fraying.

Calico

Calico is traditionally a simple, inexpensive, plain or unbleached cotton fabric. In contemporary quilting terms, however, calico can also refer to the print on the fabric rather than the fabric itself; meaning an all-over, small print, usually of a floral pattern.

Muslin

This soft, loosely woven cotton fabric is generally white or natural in colour and comes in a variety of different weights. It is typically used as a foundation fabric when foundation piecing. Good-quality muslin also makes a lovely backing fabric.

Hand-dyed and batik

With one-of-a-kind patterns, hand-dyed fabrics are becoming very popular among quilters thanks to their uniqueness. A variety of different fabrics are available hand-dyed, but cotton is best for quilting. Variations in colour and pattern can occur across a cut of hand-dyed fabric. Always pre-wash hand-dyed fabrics using a dye magnet – a product that picks up the loose dye – and a colour fixer.



Corduroy

Corduroy is soft and durable, but due to the nap and the ribs, it can be difficult to work with. Narrow-rib and pinwale corduroy are the best choices for quilting. Always use a walking foot and pre-wash the fabric. Iron carefully so as not to destroy the nap.

Blends

Many fabrics are available as a blend between two different fibres. A fabric blend can often offer the best of both in one. For example, a silk-blend will be less expensive than a pure silk fabric.